



SHOWING OFF

Several ocean birds perform spectacular courtship displays on their nesting grounds. Some of the most dramatic are those of male frigatebirds, which have brilliant red inflatable throat pouches. They display in the trees on tropical coral islands, competing with each other to attract females flying overhead.



GUANO ISLANDS

Some islands off the Pacific coast of South America have been used as seabird breeding colonies for centuries. The rocks are covered with incredibly deep layers of seabird droppings, known as guano. Some layers are more than 164 ft (50 m) deep. These deposits were once mined for use as fertilizer for farming and shipped all over the world.

OUT OF SIGHT

While seabirds such as guillemots and gannets nest on rocky ledges or the flat tops of islands, others nest in burrows. They include puffins, which will often take over old rabbit burrows to avoid having to dig their own nests. The baby puffins stay hidden in their dark burrows, where they are safe from the gulls and skuas that are their main enemies. The adults hunt in the sea nearby, returning with beakfuls of fish to feed to their young.

▼ STRONG GRIP

An Atlantic puffin can catch several small fish in one dive. It uses its strong tongue to grip the fish it has caught while seizing more in its colorful beak.

